of spiritual skill or theological conviction.

By necessity, Henry II spent a great deal of time in his chancellor's company; and he discovered that he liked Becket. The two men hunted together, ate together, drank together. Thomas, well-off for perhaps the first time in his life, copied the king's spending habits and supplied himself with lavish meals and clothes, even keeping a couple of exotic monkeys for pets and two wolves to act as hunting dogs. Henry had every reason to think that Becket was a loyal and (more importantly) pliable servant. The king nominated him to fill the vacant position, and on May 23, a month after Theobald's death, the required assembly of bishops and barons obediently elected Becket, and the chancellor became archbishop.[5]

With his elevation to the highest office of the church, Becket went through a startling and unexpected change. "As if transformed to another man," writes one of his biographers, William of Canterbury, "he became more restrained, more watchful, more frequent in prayer, more attentive in preaching." Although he had never taken monastic vows, he began to wear a monk's hair shirt—a stiff, prickly, vermin-infested garment of goat hair, meant to mortify the flesh—beneath his ecclesiastical robes. He began to eat and drink sparingly, to pray late into the night, to condemn the luxury in which he had once lived: "Every day in his private cell on bended knees he would wash the feet of thirty paupers in memory of Christ," remarks Herbert of Bosham, in awe.[6]

Contemporary chroniclers chalk this metamorphosis up to a road-to-Damascus experience with God, an awakening to divine call. But it is not so out of line with Becket's previous twenty years of service. He had always been efficient, conscientious, adaptable; and his new persona was exactly suited to the archbishop's role. To be archbishop meant to hold a loyalty higher than that of archdeacon to bishop, or of chancellor to king.

At first, the change did not strike Henry as ominous. He began to carry out his planned reforms. He announced to his bishops that he would push for clergymen convicted in church trials to be automatically stripped of their titles, making them fair game to be retried in secular court; and then he drew up a document specifying exactly how far the "rule of souls" stretched, and placed it before Becket for his approval.

This document, the Constitutions of Clarendon (after the royal palace at Clarendon where it was composed), made the king's authority supreme. Clergymen accused of crimes would be tried in the king's courts and, if convicted, would be punished by secular law. Bishops, in return, were to stay out of the affairs of laymen. No royal official could be excommunicated unless he had first been convicted by a secular court of wrongdoing; quarrels